



Community based participatory research for public relations: Realizing potential for researcher-participant relationships[☆]

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ABSTRACT

Relationship management theory and organizational-public relationships (OPR) continue to guide much of the research in public relations (PR) and espouse values of building collaborative and dialogic interactions for mutual benefit. Yet, OPR historically prioritized the use of relationships to reach organizational goals instead of public or community needs. Furthermore, the relationship paradigm has overlooked the significance of relationships between researchers and participants. This essay urges PR to prioritize researcher-participant relationships when engaging in research that concerns a community by using community-based participatory research (CBPR), an approach that values the contributions of community partners. We consider the foundations and critiques of relationships in PR and explain how CBPR can transcend some of these limitations by facilitating mutual benefit in methodological decisions. We then outline the benefits and challenges of using CBPR based on a review of studies across disciplines and the authors' reflections on employing CBPR in their research. This work builds on the PR scholarship of relationships to offer concrete ways that researchers can utilize CBPR to address community needs and prioritize participants in the research process.

1. Introduction

Relationship management theory and organizational-public relationships (OPR) continue to guide much of the research in public relations (PR). This relationship paradigm presented an opportunity to evolve from a fundamentally functionalist view of PR to one that values the interactions, partnership, and mutual benefit between organizations and publics (Botan & Taylor, 2004; Ledingham, 2003). However, scholars have critiqued the overly positive conceptualizations of relationships and pointed out that the promise of relationship theories may not be actualized in PR research and practice (Heath, 2013; Willis, 2015). OPR has historically used engagement and relationships to reach organizational goals instead of public or community needs (Dutta & Kumar, 2015; Dutta, 2019). Furthermore, relationships between researchers and publics in applied campaign and research settings are often neglected in scholarly literature. PR studies rarely explicitly take on community-based participatory research (CBPR), an approach that

values the contributions of academic, organizational, and community partners in research that concerns a community (Israel et al., 1998).

We argue that the intersections of PR and CBPR are ripe for exploration given the opportunities to fulfill the promise of a relationship paradigm as fundamentally collaborative and beneficial to both researchers and the communities in which they operate. This essay shows that using CBPR can foster these and other relationships to not only improve relationship outcomes but also to improve community welfare, which serves to transcend OPR's tradition of instrumentalizing publics. There are several links between CBPR and PR relationship management theory and practice. CBPR helps to address some fundamental limitations of the relationship paradigm by aspiring to create equitable, power sharing partnerships (Israel et al., 1998), include values of social justice (Hacker, 2013), and encourage respect for a community's culture. Through these contributions, CBPR can inspire PR research and theory that enhances mutual benefit (a key tenet of traditional relationship management theory, e.g., Ledingham, 2003) while also aligning with

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calls to consider new directions of social change in PR relationship theory (Mundy, 2021), and foster cultural understanding in relationships and communities (Vardeman-Winter, 2014a, 2014b). PR scholars can employ CBPR to inspire participant-driven initiatives that actualize theory that is grounded in cooperative and mutually beneficial relationships.

The purpose of this essay is to present the opportunities for PR researchers to use CBPR as a tool to enact the tenets of a relationship paradigm by drawing in and valuing members of the community while also better meeting community needs in PR research and practice. A secondary purpose is to spark discussion about the realities of conducting PR research grounded in community needs so that researcher-participant relationships become a priority in methodological decisions. To achieve these purposes, we consider the foundations and critiques of relationship theory in PR and then discuss how CBPR can overcome some of these critiques in researcher-participant relationships. We then outline the benefits and challenges of using CBPR based on a review of studies across disciplines and the authors' reflections on employing CBPR in their research. This work builds on the PR scholarship of relationships to offer concrete ways that researchers can utilize CBPR to address community needs and prioritize participants in the research process.

2. Literature review: reflecting on relationships

Relationship management is a core area of knowledge in PR that centers the interactions between organizations and various publics. Scholars have argued that organizational-public relationships (OPR) serve as the "unit of analysis" for public relations, which situates the relationship as the phenomenon of interest rather than either party exclusively (Ferguson, 1984; Ledingham, 2006). While Ferguson's (1984) paper served as a marker of the reorientation of PR towards relationships, scholars were positing about how organizations, publics, and communities can and should interact for decades (Cutlip & Center, 1952). For instance, Cutlip and Center (1952) included in their definition of PR, "a sincere effort to establish a mutuality of interest and thus achieve the harmonious adjustment of an institution to its community" (p. 6). Scholars of relationship management have considered a wide range of relationship elements such as relationship types (Bruning & Ledingham, 1999), the interconnections of time and relationships (Ledingham et al., 1999), and relationship measurement (Hon & Grunig, 1999). A relationship perspective became an overarching philosophical orientation set to illustrate PR's commitment to publics and communities.

Furthermore, relationships have remained relevant decades later. Ki and Shin (2015) found 124 OPR articles between the years of 1985–2013 in a range of journals using various methodologies indicating the breadth of relationship research in the field. Cheng's (2018) systematic review illuminated five research trends across the three decades of relationship/OPR research, which included relationships consequences, antecedents, OPR as a mediating variable, the process of OPR, and the structure/s of relationships. In other words, relationships remain one of the most significant and pressing areas for PR research and practice.

An important assumption of the relational paradigm of PR is that PR is a fundamentally dialogic practice where both sides of a relationship matter when attending to common interests (Dutta & Kumar, 2015). Scholars framed relationships as a state in which two entities are interconnected and the actions of one party impacts the other (Ledingham & Bruning, 1998; Hon & Grunig, 1999). Mutual benefit emerges when relationships are properly fostered (Ledingham, 2003). As Dutta and Kumar (2015) expressed, "The relationship management perspective aims to shift the overall goals of public relations away from buffering against the publics and manipulating them, to an active dialog with, and nurturing of an organization—public relationship" (p. 262). While this relationship paradigm and the theories within it promised an

approach that values publics as much as organizations, that promise remains unfilled in many cases.

PR relationship scholarship was rooted in a strategic management perspective and the discipline sought to effectively build positive relationships because of their value for organizational success (Huang & Zhang, 2015). Scholars developed variables to measure the outcomes of relationships, and many have agreed that some main factors are trust, control mutuality, satisfaction, and commitment (Hon & Grunig, 1999; Grunig & Huang, 2000). Trust is described as faith in other relationship entities and in the relationship itself (Hon & Grunig, 1999) or as an indication that an organization will follow through on its promises (Ledingham et al., 1997; Ledingham, 2006). Control mutuality represents perceived ability to affect that relationship (Hon & Grunig, 1999). Satisfaction demonstrates the positive opinions each party in the relationship has for the other (Hon & Grunig, 1999), and for the relationship, and often considers how organizations could position goods and services to meet publics' needs (Bruning & Ledingham, 1998). Lastly, commitment has been defined as the parties' display of dedication and duty to the wellbeing of others (Ledingham et al., 1997; Ledingham, 2006). The strategic management leanings and early attention to categorizing, conceptualizing, and measuring relationships acknowledged that interactions and two-way communication matter to organizational success yet still often instrumentalized publics and relationships with them.

2.1. Limitations of OPR and a relationship approach: potential unfulfilled

At the core of the critiques of OPR and relationship management is a key challenge – the discipline often fails to truly engage publics and tends to treat them as means to an end in practice and research. The paradigmatic turn toward relationships, while veiled in two-way interaction and balance of interests, was still dedicated to organizational effectiveness, and fundamentally focused on exploiting relationships for the organization's success (Dutta & Kumar, 2015; Willis, 2015). Similarly, PR research projects often overlook the public side of the relationship. As Heath (2013) asserted:

We find relationship research that, unlike that of our interpersonal communication colleagues, does not ask relational parties to comment on the relationship under consideration. Thus, we often have no data to shed light onto what factors, as enacted, strengthen or harm a relationship, as well as what discursive processes co-define and negotiate them (p. 427).

Willis (2015) argued that PR researchers and practitioners, "ignore a number of inconvenient truths" in developing a true relationship-centered approach, such as lack of true listening, and oversimplifying relationships in terms of linearity and predictability (p. 686). In many ways, there is still much work to be done to truly honor and actualize a relationship orientation in PR though some scholarship has moved forward in this aim.

Scholars have continued to challenge the limitations of relationships when considering how to encourage listening and prioritize marginalized voices in communication processes (Dutta & Kumar, 2015) and how PR can facilitate change empowerment through relationships (Mundy, 2021). Specifically, Vardeman-Winter (2014a) argued that PR practitioners must reflect on their relationships with participants "to better know how publics' cultural experiences affect their communication behaviors" (p. 91). This scholarship highlights that without engaging publics fully and without a willingness to prioritize their interests, practitioners and researchers risk not truly addressing their needs in PR efforts, such as communication campaigns and social advocacy.

Furthermore, relationship management has left out a detailed discussion of research participants as a specific type of public that delivers valuable data for researchers and practitioners. Participants in academic and practice-oriented research are publics. They have relationships with

researchers and their institutions, and practitioners and their organizations. They often volunteer their time to provide pertinent data and perspectives. Despite the mutually beneficial focus of a relationship approach to PR, the discipline has not fully adopted research practices that value participants as key influencers of initiatives or built projects around community needs. Thus, we have an opportunity to center participants as publics in the research process and ensure that their needs and desires are also met. For the purposes of this essay, we use the term *researcher-participant relationships* (Vardeman-Winter, 2014a) to highlight a specific type of relationship in need of attention and position CBPR as a key step towards realizing PR's relationship-focused promise in research contexts.

3. Why CBPR for PR? Considering researcher-participant relationships

CBPR adds value to the methodological decisions within PR research by privileging participants' lived experiences and defining effectiveness of research as meeting community needs. CBPR is a collaborative approach designed to ensure that stakeholders (i.e., community members and local organizations) who are affected by the issue being studied can participate alongside researchers throughout the research and implementation process (Hacker, 2013; Viswanathan et al., 2004). Because such a research approach invites participants that live the phenomenon to help investigate and address issues within their communities, "the potential increases to address locally identified priorities and outcomes, including inequitable social conditions" (Sánchez et al., 2021, p. 285).

We use the term CBPR throughout this paper to refer to research that intentionally draws in participants to address community issues, though CBPR goes by a variety of names, such as "participatory research" and "action research" (Hacker, 2013, p. 4). Also, many approaches share core values, principles, and processes with CBPR, such as a culture-centered approach (CCA) (Dutta, 2018) and feminist studies approaches (Vardeman-Winter, 2014a). Numerous fields are well known for their use of CBPR and related approaches such as education, organizational communication, medicine, and public health (Holkup et al., 2004; McDermott et al., 2008; Salimi et al., 2012). However, CBPR or other similar orientations to research are underutilized in PR despite their potential to give teeth to the relationship-centered focus of the field and complement a variety of research aims.

CBPR serves as both a theoretical and methodological orientation rather than a particular method itself (Minkler, 2005, p. ii5), and so it is often flexible enough to meet the topical and methodological diversity of the PR field. CBPR can be used alongside various research methods (Viswanathan et al., 2004), such as ethnography, focus groups and interviews, and can inform quantitative methodology, such as surveys. Community research also occurs along what scholars have explained as a continuum that spans varying levels of community member participation (Hacker, 2013; Palmer-Wackerly et al., 2014). This continuum ranges from researcher-directed projects that include community members at certain points to projects that incorporate "an intense collaboration" (Palmer-Wackerly et al., 2014, p. 261) for involved groups. Thus, researchers can choose how and to what extent they can focus on researcher-participant relationships. In terms of *how* CBPR transcends organization-centric relationship theory, privileges participants' experiences, and situates effectiveness as serving community interests, we outline its prioritization of collaboration, social justice, and respect for community culture for PR research.

3.1. Collaboration as partnerships with publics

A relationship approach promised more collaborative processes between organizations and publics (Botan & Taylor, 2004; Ledingham, 2006) for which CBPR has tangible principles and strategies to enact such collaboration with research participants. For instance, Israel et al.

(1998) outlined several principles of CBPR, and many serve as praxis for a relational approach to PR. CBPR must 1) acknowledge community membership as a form of identity; 2) cultivate community assets and resources; 3) promote partnerships in all steps of the research process; 4) fuse information gained with action "for mutual benefit of all partners"; 5) encourage a mutual learning process that is sensitive to the inequities that have marginalized communities; 6) include a research process that is "cyclical and iterative;" and 7) share research findings and information with partners (Israel et al., 1998, pp. 178–180). Each of these principles highlights the importance of building alliances with participants and conducting research projects that bring positive outcomes to all partners. Through such an approach, researcher-public relationships can be more equitable and balanced because participants have a voice and access to crucial information throughout the research process that reflects and impacts their lived experience.

CBPR also illuminates an important component missing from relationship theories in PR – the distinctions between relationships and partnerships. Partnership implies that all parties are included in decision making (Israel et al., 2006). Because partnerships represent a type of relationship in which power is shared (Hacker, 2013), partnerships can be very meaningful for addressing communal problems. As an example, Simmons et al. (2015) included 23 community partner organizations in research aimed at reducing cancer disparities. Organizational partners specialized in areas such as survivor support, health education, and health care services. The CBPR participants reported that the project provided "collaborative, equitable partnerships," instances for each partner to offer expertise, and opportunities to learn from one another (Simmons et al., 2015, p. 7). Adding the concept of partnership to the PR relationship lexicon and considering how participants can serve as full-fledged, power-wielding entities pushes PR to acknowledge its consequence and influence while engaging in research that affects a community.

3.2. Considering social justice in communities

Recent scholarship has demonstrated how PR can serve as a vehicle for social justice where practitioners, researchers, teachers, etc. "engage voices, build relationships, and facilitate change" (Golombisky, 2015, p. 409) and can enable relationships with publics to enact social justice (Mundy, 2021). One way that PR can achieve this social justice service is to use CBPR as a methodological orientation that promotes equity by privileging participants' experiences and honoring their ability to drive change. Social justice means that communities have "the sustainable material and social circumstances in which all people enjoy general wellbeing, participate in self-determining communities, and thrive in the pursuit of fulfilling lives" (Golombisky, 2015, pp. 389–390).

CBPR emerged from feminist theory and theories of community organizing to prioritize issues of social justice through the sharing of power to assert that knowledge creation about community issues originates from people within the community (Hacker, 2013). In terms of facilitating change within a community, CBPR projects often provide useful tools to achieve goals of participants and partners rather than researchers alone (Plumb et al., 2004). Such tools can include data and community skills to activate policy change (Plumb et al., 2004) or the development of community members' buy-in to public health campaigns or social advocacy efforts. Developing researcher-participant relationships and making methodological decisions that empower participants can further refine PR's contribution to society as enabling community-driven improvements.

Espousing a relationship-centered discipline within an inequitable society suggests that PR researchers have obligations to improve communities through their research and practice, which scholars have explored. At the intersections of social justice and relationships, Mundy (2021) argued that relationship management should evolve to "change empowerment" in order to prioritize public voice and action for pressing social justice causes, such as LGBTQ advocacy (p. 505). Avenues to

empower publics in research that aligns with social justice responsibilities also exist when researchers seek out marginalized publics to reflect on health campaigns (Vardeman-Winter, 2011), engage marginalized publics on social media (Place, 2021), and employ feminist cultural approaches to campaign development (Vardeman-Winter, 2014a). For these initiatives aimed at employing PR theory and practice to fulfill commitments to social justice, CBPR provides a robust methodological framework to systematically consider researcher-participant relationships throughout the research process.

3.3. *Respecting culture and community*

Culture remains a longstanding challenge for PR practice and research. Figuring out what culture is (Sriramesh, 2012), understanding PR as a sociocultural activity (Edwards & Hodges, 2011), and determining how to develop relationships within different cultures (Huang & Zhang, 2015, p. 19) are key areas where PR researchers have invested their time. CBPR and related approaches help researchers and practitioners consider cultural realities in underserved communities (Dutta, 2010, 2018, 2019; Hodges & McGrath, 2011) by building grassroots relationships that are grounded in participants' cultures. For instance, Basu and Dutta (2009) interviewed community members and partners in West Bengal, India to understand two sex-worker-run HIV/AIDS programs. They argued for a culture centered participatory approach (CCA) that moves beyond asking participants for their responses to preconceived campaigns and instead looks to participants to culturally situate entire initiatives. While CCA has slightly different emphases than CBPR, such as facilitating community participation in addressing issues rather than bringing researchers and stakeholders together to address issues (Dutta, 2018), these two approaches are closely related, and their core values are well-suited to engage in relationships that respect a community's culture.

Relationships that center participants' culture are not only more respectful but can also be more effective in meeting the research and/or project goals. Such research can "reduce communicator–publics gaps" by creating connections among and negotiating interests of researchers, organizations, community entities, and participants (Vardeman-Winter, 2014b, p. 125). For example, Vardeman-Winter (2014b) interviewed community health workers, health educators, and leaders at grassroots organizations to understand their strategies to engage communities and create culturally informed materials/campaigns and found that these participants often witnessed better health outcomes and communication when partnering with communities for input. We posit that these participants engaged in a form of CBPR as communication practitioners, which emphasizes the practical value of the approach.

So far, this essay has argued that relationship management has not truly embodied the two-way, mutual benefit it initially espoused. There is a lack of attention to researcher-public relationships, and CBPR can help address such limitations. It presents three ways that CBPR can actualize a relationship-centered approach between researchers and participants, by enacting collaboration and partnerships, incorporating social justice, and respecting community culture. In this next section, we present reflections from the literature and authors' firsthand experience of implementing CBPR. We detail both the benefits and costs to help researchers make informed decisions about when and why to utilize such an approach.

4. **Practicing CBPR in PR research: reflections from literature and experience**

Disciplines that have strong steams of CBPR research, such as public and community health, have documented the costs, benefits, and challenges of conducting community-driven research (e.g., Israel et al., 1998). Both authors also have experience with CBPR related to different communication and campaign projects for community health (e.g., Aghazadeh & Aldoory, 2020; Aldoory et al., 2015). While the purpose of

this section is not to provide an empirical review of any particular project, we present some of our reflections from a CBPR project in which both authors participated that addressed prediabetes awareness in a local community. Prediabetes leads to Type 2 diabetes, and also increases a person's risk for stroke and heart disease though it can be reversed through lifestyle changes (Centers for Disease Control and Prevention [CDC], 2020). The purpose of this project was to collect data to inform messages for a prediabetes awareness campaign in a local, high-risk community. The authors/researchers worked with the local county health department, who in this case was the "organization" – the entity designing, producing, and disseminating the campaign to the community. The researchers acted as liaisons between the health department and the local residents (publics/participants) and conducted formative research to design messages and tactics for the campaign. We draw on these reflections in the literature and from experience to provide a realistic account of what taking on CBPR looks like and to provide actionable steps for PR researchers interested in applying this orientation to their work.

4.1. *Reflection 1: consider study aims*

It is not our intent to argue that CBPR is appropriate for every PR research project. CBPR best complements research that seeks to address inequities within communities (Minkler, 2005; Minkler & Baden, 2008) and is also equipped to incorporate actions and interventions to address such inequities. For example, if a PR researcher seeks to understand cultural and community perceptions of climate change and plans to employ a communication effort to promote environmental justice, CBPR may be a well-suited approach. Furthermore, CBPR researchers often engage with communities to create and/or revise research questions to ensure they are addressing the needs of a particular community (Minkler & Baden, 2008). Thus, PR researchers must consider to what extent their study is meant to address issues within a community and to what extent they can ground the project's direction in community needs before employing CBPR.

Researchers taking on CBPR must reflect deeply about the fit of their overarching research aims and questions because failing to do so can corrupt trust with marginalized publics. A major benefit of CBPR is that it can overcome lack of trust between researchers and underserved communities that have traditionally experienced negative consequences from research (Peterson, 2010; Peterson et al., 2012). Underserved communities that have engaged with CBPR are wide ranging and have included Native American communities (Peterson, 2010; Thomas et al., 2009), people experiencing housing instability/homelessness (Peterson et al., 2012), rural populations (Corbie-Smith et al., 2011; Garney et al., 2015), and racially and ethnically diverse communities (Frett et al., 2016). However, if study aims do not coalesce with privileging participants' perspectives and facilitating their own initiatives it runs the risk of diminishing these benefits of CBPR.

4.2. *Reflection 2: question epistemological assumptions*

When embarking on a CBPR research project, researchers must question their epistemological assumptions and consider the challenges that more traditional research philosophies may pose to a less traditional research approach. Given its focus on equity and partnership, CBPR is most commensurable with social constructionist, feminist, and critical worldviews (Hacker, 2013; Minkler & Baden, 2008) and researchers must ensure that their questions and project purposes align with such philosophies. But traditional research epistemology privileges researchers as 'experts' that are best suited to control many aspects of a project (Hacker, 2013). For instance, in health communication campaign contexts communication experts and health professionals are seen as the knowledge producers who create, test, and disseminate messages for consumption. Epistemological leanings of universities and desired publishers of this research must also be questioned (Minkler &

Baden, 2008) for studies seeking specific types of funding, publication, and other accolades. Validity, reliability, and objectivity in CBPR are often counter to traditional positivist approaches, but input from community members can improve these and other research methods.

An epistemology that privileges participant expertise can bring improved relationships and tangible benefits to researchers as well as communities. Through CBPR, community stakeholders serve as experts of their own lived experiences and can benefit the research process by improving recruitment, data collection, data analysis, dissemination, and social action (Flicker, 2008; Minkler, 2005). With input from community members, researchers can develop meaningful messages and interventions, and can consider the benefits and risks of the research for community members (Minkler, 2005). For instance, when working on our project related to prediabetes prevention in a community, we did not create health messages and then “test” them among a random sample or in the community. Instead, we went to community stakeholders and asked what, where, and how people would like messages about prediabetes.

4.3. Reflection 3: attending to relationships throughout the research process

Traditional research often focuses on recruitment and data collection as times when researchers are interacting with participants but CBPR positions relationships as a central consideration throughout the entirety of a research project and across related projects. CBPR scholars have divided up the relationship approach into phases, which can help researchers attend to this dynamic and ongoing interaction between researchers and participants. The initial phase is for researchers to form and maintain partnerships (Israel, Eng, et al, 2005, Israel et al., 2012; Livingood et al., 2017). Next steps guide researchers to assess community needs, determine the issue at hand, and document and evaluate the partnership process (Israel et al., 2005; Livingood et al., 2017). Lastly, researchers should solicit feedback/interpretations and share applicable results (Israel et al., 2005; Livingood et al., 2017). Israel et al. (2012) added to these phases by arguing that researchers should continue to reflect on existing relationships. Therefore, CBPR researchers cannot limit their attention to relationships with participants at any point in time but must constantly nurture and interrogate the relationships at the heart of their work. Table 1 shows some specific strategies at each phase and throughout the research process to help illustrate how relationships could be built and maintained throughout a CBPR PR project.

4.4. Reflection 4: consider CBPR challenges realistically

While this essay has argued for the use of CBPR to consider researcher-participant relationships more deliberately and consistently in PR research, we do not encourage researchers to use such an approach blindly. Just as relationships are messy (Willis, 2015), a CBPR approach presents distinct challenges and may not fit a particular research purpose. We have outlined four related challenges that researchers should consider before embarking on CBPR projects.

4.4.1. Time

When researchers share control of a project and encourage shared ownership via partnership, they also compromise their ability to control timelines in a variety of ways including the time to build trust and the limited time that participants may have for a partnership. For instance, Palmer-Wackerly et al. (2014) listed a central challenge of CBPR as the time required to cultivate trusting partnerships. Basu and Dutta (2009) spent about one year developing trust and rapport with a local partner to gain access to a community. Efforts to build trust between researchers and underserved communities as well as between community groups can detract from the research goals and must be considered strategically (Israel et al., 2005).

Another challenge related to time is that community members often

Table 1
Strategies for Attending to Researcher-Participant Relationships in PR.

Phase	Potential Strategies
Form and Maintain	- Attend community and neighborhood meetings - Dedicate research time to outreach and relationship building - Systematically contact local organizations invested in related work via phone and email as potential access points - Nurture relationships with trusted leaders and “champions” in the community to help gain access
Assess Community Needs/ Determine Issues	- Conduct pilot studies with key community stakeholders - Create advisory boards for continual feedback about community needs - Partner with local non-profits, municipalities, or other local organizations that are deeply immersed in the community’s needs and issues
Document and Evaluate Partnerships	- Create lists of all partners to share within the community - Memo/reflect on partnership evolution - Establish systems that allow community partners to meet each other and share resources (e.g., hosting update meetings or tabling community events)
Solicit Feedback/Share Results	- Share PR materials and plans with community members before official campaign or communication efforts begin - Provide accessible versions of initial data analysis or research summaries for community input - Seek feedback about the experience of participating from partners and participants
Reflect on Existing Relationships	- Consider how to engage partners and participants across projects with similar communities and/or topics - Determine if/how participants would like to be contacted after a project’s closing - Dedicate time to following up with partners post-project

Israel, Eng, et al. (2005), Israel et al. (2012), Livingood et al. (2017).

have limited time for research needs. For instance, Young et al. ‘s (2015) project found that volunteers had to balance work, personal commitments, and other volunteer projects. Even though the health department had existing relationships with many of the churches for the faith-based community project to build upon, these challenges persisted as the project grew (Young et al., 2015).

4.4.2. Required flexibility

Working with community participants as partners in the research process requires researchers to remain nimble and able to adapt to community needs or unexpected challenges. In our own CBPR project, we found that schedules and priorities were not ours to dictate, and we had to be flexible and act quickly in order to mobilize for last minute events, such as community meetings. Sometimes personnel at community organizations could not be reached because they were too busy, moved locations, or the organization was no longer operating. Moreover, the inability to control all aspects of research could present challenges for funders and participants (Israel et al., 1988). Again, researchers must be prepared to handle a variety of unknowns when taking on a project that shares control with community partners.

4.4.3. Resource limitations

While it is not necessary to have research funding to engage in CBPR, funding can provide incentives to community participants and a budget to make intervention and communication materials. For instance, our diabetes awareness project included “goody bags” for those who attended meetings, filled with water bottles, pedometers, exercise cards, fact sheet/brochure, printed prediabetes risk test, exercise bands, and recipe cards. Ultimately, there were more requests for diabetes group meetings and feedback sessions than could be supported by the local health department within its timeline and funding constraints.

While conducting CBPR without funding can be challenging, it is not impossible. For instance, Silka et al. (2008)'s Research Initiative Working Group (RIWG) employed a non-funded CBPR project to derive guidelines for ethical research within an underserved Massachusetts community. The authors expressed that a lack of funding can strain CBPR partnerships "but that same lack of funding can also be an opportunity for building partnership resilience. We have found that the struggles have become a source for building partnership and overcoming obstacles" (Silka et al., 2008, p. 10). Researchers seeking to employ CBPR without funding can focus on incentives for participants that are not monetary, such as developing research skills, gaining volunteer experience, and garnering useful data to help make community decisions. In terms of interventions, researchers may seek out campaign messaging and materials that do not cost money, such as linking into existing community meetings and social media campaigns to share information. Ultimately, CBPR is an orientation to research that builds research around community needs and prioritizes participant agency, and those basic values do not have to cost money.

4.4.4. Potential negative effects for a community

Even with the best intentions, it is not possible for researchers to remain involved with the same intensity over years and amidst the many institutional and funding barriers. This means that researchers may leave a gap in the community if they must leave before community members and partners are equipped with the tools and skills to continue the work. Furthermore, organizational or institutional goals can supersede community ones due to various economic and political pressures that further perpetuate inequalities in communities (Dutta & Kumar, 2015).

Scholars have argued that CBPR tends to idealize power sharing between researchers, community members, and community organizations (Chandanabhumma et al., 2019). This challenges the assumed opportunities for social justice outcomes and disparity reduction. These considerations parallel critical PR scholarship that has questioned if equitable relationships between organizations and publics (or researchers and participants) are possible (Leitch & Motion, 2010). While these challenges are real and persistent in CBPR research, if the study aims are properly aligned with facilitating change and promoting equity in a community, it has the potential to empower a community and enhance its existing strengths.

4.5. Reflection 5: build upon community strengths

When taking on a CBPR approach, it is important to realize community strengths and existing resources that are already prepared to serve community needs. In line with previous CBPR literature, we have found in our CBPR projects that community members were indispensable guides in the research process. They decided communication directions and materials (e.g., Hacker, 2013; Livingood et al., 2017) and helped leverage community resources to reach people. In the prediabetes prevention campaign, "Lifestyle Champions" were prominent leaders in the community who agreed to promote healthy living and awareness in their communities and many of these champions were leaders in the local community and had existing relationships with the second author. The champions helped us link into existing meetings and gain access to participants. For example, we attended a community dinner at a local church in which the champion (pastor) served as a trusted liaison between researchers and the church, introduced us to charitable organizations, and encouraged community members to come speak to us and share their thoughts about prediabetes.

Researchers must acknowledge the strengths of each partner and distribute decision-making power in line with each entity's expertise. Integrating a community's already existing resources allows researchers to employ community knowledge, utilize the community's network, and provide sustainable change (Hamilton et al., 2017). Furthermore, building upon existing community resources can promote more

sustainable change by fully embedding those changes into the community, avoiding redundancy, and encouraging participant buy-in (Hacker, 2013; Israel et al., 1998; Livingood et al., 2017). Focusing on the strengths of the community and leveraging them throughout the research process brings us to our last reflection related to humility.

4.6. Reflection 6: embrace humility

Researchers, community members, and community partners each have specific and equally important roles to play in CBPR research, which can promote a sense of humility within the researcher-participant relationship. While such humility is encouraged and expected from CBPR approaches as an underlying moral ideal (Schaffer, 2009), it is rarely explicitly discussed in public relations theory and practice. Community members and partners are the experts of their community's needs and researchers are the experts of their respective fields. For instance, in the CBPR project for prediabetes prevention we attempted to communicate a sense of humbleness in the beginning stages of relationship development by recruiting community members through the slogan "tell us how to do our job" at health fairs and community events.

In this same prediabetes awareness project, humility also emerged as cultural humility in that we as two white researchers did not assume we could fully grasp the culture of a predominately Black community; we remained open to learning and participating (Fisher-Borne et al., 2015). For example, we arrived early to meetings to learn norms for the different local groups (e.g., city council meetings, church community dinners, senior group meetings, etc.) We prioritized meeting champions and community members' children and friends to further engage with their communities. In a CBPR approach, the researcher's ability to take on a sense of modesty and question their self-importance can help provide an appropriate mindset to best serve the communities at the center of their work.

4.7. Future research and conclusion

We have synthesized the potential value of CBPR for PR and these arguments highlight the much-needed empirical work that was beyond the scope of this essay. For instance, empirical projects that employ CBPR in PR should include feedback mechanisms for participants to comment on their experiences and perceptions of researcher-participant relationships. Some opportunities for future research include PR studies that utilize and reflect on a CBPR approach for different contexts and communities. Future research that applies CBPR to non-health related contexts would be fruitful in understanding other research topics that would benefit from such an approach. Autoethnographic and researcher-reflexive accounts of PR studies taking on CBPR could help researchers consider their role in the welfare of a community.

CBPR has become a popular approach to address a host of community issues, particularly health concerns and inequities. Even though CBPR is largely oriented towards relationship

building within communities and between researchers and participants, PR researchers rarely utilize it. PR scholars can use CBPR as a tool to harness relationships for participant-driven initiatives situated in the promise of a relational, collaborative PR perspective. Despite its assets, it is important for researchers to consider that CBPR is not without its challenges. We urge researchers to continue to seek the intersections of CBPR and PR and reap the rewards of their synergy.

This essay outlined the relationship paradigm of PR and the promise it offers for collaboration between organizations and publics coupled with the lack of attention to participants as publics in the research process. It outlined how CBPR helps to address some fundamental limitations of the relational paradigm by allowing for true collaboration via partnerships, moving the field and its research towards social justice, and respecting community culture. This essay then presented reflections for using CBPR in PR projects and research, addressing both the benefits and challenges of such an approach so that researchers can consider the

utility for their own projects.

To be sure, relationships are complex, and PR has struggled to define, measure, and fully understand them. OPR has often been used to engage publics in relationships to achieve organization-centered goals rather than the goals of a community (Dutta & Kumar, 2015; Dutta, 2019). However, this essay proposed that researchers consider how a focus on researcher-participant relationships could facilitate community-driven solutions and how a CBPR approach can foster relationships to improve community welfare. Particularly when PR research is aimed at creating tangible resources to address community needs, researchers should consider CBPR approaches to draw in community members and partners. While challenges accompany CBPR, the long-term benefits to researchers and importantly, the community, often outweigh the costs.

Competing interest statement

The authors have no conflict of interests to declare.

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